

BREECH-LOADING CARBINES

Muzzle-loading carbines were impractical to use on horseback as it was difficult to load them while riding. This was also a problem for muzzle-loading rifles, but infantry could manage these relatively inexpensive weapons. As a result, many military authorities recognized the potential benefits of a breech-loading carbine, and carbines became one of the first military arms to be converted to breech-loading. In the 1850s and 1860s, many types of breech-loading mechanism were developed. The availability of percussion ignition (see pp.80–81) technology and improved manufacturing methods fuelled a rapid increase in the conversion of carbines in the mid-19th century. These weapons fired a fully combustible paper cartridge carrying the powder charge and bullet.

▼ GREENE CARBINE

Date 1855

Origin US

Barrel 22in (56cm)

Caliber .54in

The Greene Carbine, produced in small numbers for the British Army during the Crimean War (1853–56), lost out to its rivals due to its cumbersome mechanism. The barrel had to be rotated through a quarter-turn: this unlocked the breech, which was then free to swing out so that a new cartridge could be introduced.

▲ SHARPS CARBINE

Date 1848

Origin US

Barrel 18in (45.5cm)

Caliber .52in

This breech-loader used a sliding breechblock to load a combustible cartridge, which was ignited by a tape primer (see p.81) or, in later models, a percussion cap.

